

The One Beneath the Tree

The tannery sat beneath the sprawling limbs of the Grandfather Tree, its modest frame tucked among the roots as if the forest itself had grown around it rather than allowed it to be built. Within its walls, Ferris worked as he always had—steady hands shaping leather, careful eyes scanning the grain for imperfections. He was methodical, disciplined, a man shaped by craft and quiet duty. Yet beneath that practiced steadiness lay something else.

Grief.

It had settled deep within him, woven into his movements, into the way he lingered over his brother's chair—polishing the wood though no one sat there anymore. He did not speak of it. There was little point in words when silence told the story well enough.

The treants moved through the grove, their pace slow, deliberate, reverent. Their presence, like the ancient tree itself, seemed unchanged by time, carrying the weight of ages in every deliberate step. Life continued beneath the Grandfather Tree's watchful gaze—merchants whispering in quiet tones, the scent of moss clinging to damp earth, a world that had known loss and yet endured.

Rumors drifted like wind through the branches, voices speaking of distant things—of fate, of prophecy, of those touched by forces beyond their understanding. The spirits stirred uneasily, their quiet murmurs threading through the air, tangled in something unseen.

And in the silence, understanding lingered—unspoken, yet felt.

And so, the tale begins—where Yaereene "Yae" Inphyra and Ferris cross paths, their grief entwined like roots beneath the Grandfather Tree. A meeting shaped not by fate alone, but by the weight of choices yet to be made.

This moment, quiet yet undeniable, sets the course for what must come next.

☒ Her Arrival

It had been a few weeks since the treants brought her in.

She didn't cry. Didn't speak much, either. But she carried grief like it was stitched into her bones—

sharp and heavy and old

. Still, she stood steady. There was something strong underneath. A kind of resolve. Not loud, but stubborn.

She came into my shop like she'd done it before, like she was walking a path she couldn't avoid. And the spirits stirred when she passed, like they recognized her

.

"Yae, are you?" I asked.

I didn't need the answer. I already knew.

She nodded.

I'd heard the whispers, same as everyone else. Said she might be a goddess. Maybe they weren't wrong. Her presence was druidic, sure—but different. Like it came from somewhere deeper. The sort of weight you don't get just by studying old rites. This was someone who'd lived something

ancient

.

"What do you need?" I asked.

"Enchanted studded leather," she said.

Seemed straightforward enough, but when I asked for specifics, she gave me something else entirely.

"A breastplate, dyed sky blue. Leggings, darker blue. A helmet, undyed—all woven through with this plant."

"And a battle dress, sky blue, for formal occasions."

A battle dress.

That caught me. I was about to ask why—but the plant she held out drew my eye first.

Feybloom, I thought. But it shimmered, just beyond the visible spectrum. Not like any I'd worked with before.

"This is... feybloom?" I asked.

"Yes," she said.

"But not from these plains. From my homeland."

The weight in that sentence—

distant, but carried

. She brought it with her. Like memory wrapped in roots.

"Aha," I said, feeling the tingle of excitement.

"May I take some for research?"

"I'll bring you some as part of your payment."

Generous. But she had the blessing of the Tree. Kindness like that doesn't surprise me anymore.

"Aren't you the one who tends the Tree?" I asked.

"Yes."

That was enough to know.

"Forgetting your order for a moment... what exactly is a battle dress?" I asked.

She answered. Not with pride. With something older. Her voice was like wind in old bark.

"A dress woven with vines and leaves. In my case, Feydorian feybloom, bound with padding, the knees flexible. A rare request, I imagine?"

I nodded.

"I'll get to work."

☒ The Craft

Good craft takes time. This time, it took something more.

Three days.

The dye from her feybloom swirled like the stormlit sea. That plant... it sang when I worked it. Not out loud. Just under the skin.

She returned.

"Hello, Ferris."

"Aye, hello, Yae."

But her eyes weren't on the armor. They were on his chair. Brell's chair. My brother's.

"That'll be five thousand gold pieces and the Feydorian feybloom," I said, looking down.

She saw it—my grief. Clear as I saw hers.

"The chair. A family member, then? One no longer with the blessing of the Tree?"

she asked, in Druidic.

"Yes. My brother made it. He passed defending the Forest from... enemies. They did not understand. They spoke of some wood-looking half-elf."

I looked at her.

"Perhaps that was you?"

She didn't answer that. Just studied the chair.

"Your brother was a good woodcrafter."

"Yes, yes. He was that kind of druid."

"He—"

I stopped. The tears came without asking.

"He was perfect."

Then, in Common, she asked:

"Thank you very much. Oh, and what was your brother's name?"

☒ The Note

A few days passed.

Then I saw it: her note on the tavern's board. At first glance, just another job. But the shimmer on the parchment—

Feybloom at the crest

. Not local.

Written in Druidic.

It was meant for me.

To Ferris, the high elf of the tannery.

You mirrored my grief in your shop quite well.

My mother died indirectly at the hands of a corrosive lich, and my... father... I don't know how he is doing.

He was the king of my homeland, but was forcibly usurped when the elven and fey under his reign were corrupted by this lich's evildoings.

My mother and I fled, under chase. I was hunted still, but by luck, ended up here. You were the first to read this emotion that is still raw. Please, Ferris, consider travelling with me. I suspect those who killed your brother— who was an excellent person, no doubt— will do the same. You are powerful, and should be using this power for good. Please consider it. If you do agree, leave a message with Feydorian feybloom next to mine saying as much. Once I receive it, I will come seek you at the tannery.

I await your response,

Yaereene "Yae" Inphyra, Keeper of the Tree, High Forest

I didn't hesitate.

I pinned my bloom beside hers and wrote:

To Yaereene "Yae" Inphyra, Keeper of the Tree.

I have seen much pass through this forest—seasons, battles, loss. But I have never seen grief woven quite as clearly as yours, and I have never felt my own reflected so plainly in another's eyes.

You asked me to step forward, to wield my power not in quiet remembrance but in action. And I find that I cannot turn away.

You are right—those who took my brother will not stop. And if they move still, then I will meet them not as a crafter, but as the druid I have always been.

You have my answer. The Feydorian feybloom beside your letter will tell you as much, but these words will make it clear: I will go with you.

—Ferris, your guardian

☒ The Waiting

It took time. Nearly a year.

She didn't write again. I didn't need her to.

I trained an apprentice—
left the tannery in good hands

.

Every night, I did the same three things:

- Shined Brell's chair.
- Sharpened my broadsword.
- Strung my bow.

And I waited.

Not out of fear.

But with purpose.

Because I understood now:

I had not been
living

in my grief.

I had been

waiting

in it.

And waiting would no longer be enough.